

SPACING

DOC NO. RL-BRAND-001-SPACE-A REV. A RIPOSTE LABORATORIES

Riposte spacing is a loose 2px grid. "Loose" is doing work in that sentence: the scale is not a strict geometric ramp, because it was lifted from a real production site where the values earned their places. Use a step. If you find yourself wanting a value that isn't on the scale, you almost certainly want the neighbouring step instead.

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SEC.01

1 • THE SCALE

--space-1	4px	--space-4	16px	--space-7	48px
--space-2	8px	--space-5	24px	--space-8	64px
--space-3	12px	--space-6	34px	--space-9	72px

Read it as three bands:

BAND	STEPS	GOVERNS
Intimate – inside a component	1-3 (4/8/12)	Chip padding, gaps between a label and its value, list-item spacing
Structural – between components	4-6 (16/24/34)	Card padding, paragraph spacing, column gaps, the space under a section head
Architectural – between regions	7-9 (48/64/72)	Block separation, section padding, page rhythm

The rule of thumb: **never jump more than one band at a time.** A 4px gap next to a 64px gap reads as a mistake; 4 → 16 → 64 reads as hierarchy.

STEP-BY-STEP

STEP	VALUE	CANONICAL USE
-space-1	4px	Chip vertical padding (3px 9px rounds to this band), tight glyph gaps
-space-2	8px	Inline gaps in a .pills row, bottom margin, spec-header gap
-space-3	12px	Button vertical padding, chip horizontal padding, small card inset
-space-4	16px	The default. Card padding, <p> bottom margin, note padding
-space-5	24px	Button horizontal padding, gap between two related blocks
-space-6	34px	Grid column gap; the space below a .sechead; between stacked cards
-space-7	48px	Between major blocks within one section
-space-8	64px	Section padding (padding-block) on subpages
-space-9	72px	Section padding on the homepage, where sections need more air

SEC.02

2 • CONTAINERS

Every container is **viewport-capped**. This is not optional: an uncapped 1060px container touches the edge of a phone screen, and bone paper with no margin stops reading as paper.

TOKEN	VALUE	USE
-container	min(1060px, 92vw)	Standard section. The default.
--container-wide	min(1160px, 94vw)	TOC-plus-content and other two-rail layouts
--container-prose	min(900px, 92vw)	Blog posts, single-column documents
-measure	66ch	Body copy max width
-gutter	4vw	Minimum breathing room at any viewport

CSS

```
.wrap { width: min(var(--container), calc(100vw - 2 * var(--gutter))); margin-inline: auto; }
```

Measure beats container. A 1060px container does not mean 1060px of text. Body copy caps at 66ch (≈ 62rem at our size); lead paragraphs pull tighter to 56–62ch because bold text at a larger size needs a shorter line to stay readable. If a paragraph is running the full width of a wide container, the container is wrong, not the measure.

SEC.03

3 • VERTICAL RHYTHM

There is no baseline grid. There is a **stack order**, and it is consistent:

```
section
├ padding-block: 64px (--space-8)      ← the region's air
└ .sechead                             ← SEC chip + title + slash tag
```

```
| | └ padding-bottom: 14px, border-bottom: 2px
| └ margin-bottom: 34px (--space-6)           ← the gap a sechead always earns
| └ content
|   └ p margin-bottom: 16px (--space-4)
|     └ .grid gap: 34px (--space-6)
└ next block: margin-top 48px (--space-7)
```

Three rules govern it:

1. **A section head always owns 34px beneath it.** Not 32, not 40. This single value is what makes different pages feel like the same document.
2. **Paragraph spacing is 16px and margins collapse downward only.** Headings carry `margin: 0 0 16px` – never top margin. Space belongs to the element **above** the gap.
3. **The last child of a container never adds trailing margin.** The container's padding is the bottom edge. `.spec li:last-child { border-bottom: none }` is the same instinct.

SEC.04

4 • THE BORDER-EATS-PADDING RULE

This is the one that trips people up, and it is specific to a system drawn in 2px rules.

Every structural border is **2px**, and every accent bar is **6px** (top) or **8px** (left). Those widths sit **outside** the padding box. So a card with `border: 2px` and `padding: 16px` has 18px of visual inset – and a card with `border-top: 6px solid pink` has 16px of inset on three sides and 22px on top.

Do not compensate. The slight top-heaviness is correct: the accent bar is a masthead, and mastheads sit proud. What you must **not** do is mix bordered and unbordered cards in the same row – the 2px difference reads as misalignment across a grid.

COMPONENT	BORDER	PADDING	EFFECTIVE INSET
.spec header	2px bottom	8px 12px	8/12
.spec body	2px all	16px 14px	18/16
.note	2px + 8px left	14px 16px	16/18, 22 left
.partner	2px + 6px top	16px	18/18, 22 top
.stat	2px all	20px 18px	22/20

SEC.05

5 • GRID & GUTTERS

Columns are equal-width and the gap is **always -space-6 (34px)**, at every break-point where columns exist. Below 760px, grids collapse to one column and the 34px becomes vertical spacing – the value does not change, only its axis.

CSS

```
.grid { display: grid; gap: var(--space-6); }
```

```
@media (min-width: 760px) {
  .grid-2 { grid-template-columns: repeat(2, 1fr); }
  .grid-3 { grid-template-columns: repeat(3, 1fr); }
  .grid-4 { grid-template-columns: repeat(4, 1fr); }
}
```

The **.flow exception**. Process steps are joined by → arrows that live in the gap, so **.flow .step** uses **margin-right: 26px** rather than **grid gap** – the arrow needs a box to be absolutely positioned into. At ≤640px the arrow rotates to ↓, the margin goes to 0 and a 22px flex gap takes over. This is the only place in the system where a spacing value is off-scale, and it is off-scale because a glyph has to fit inside it.

SEC.06

6 • BREAKPOINTS

Three, and only three. The system is fluid between them via **clamp()**, so there is very little to change at each stop.

BREAKPOINT	WHAT HAPPENS
560px	footer.colophon goes from two columns to one; the tri-band cell left-aligns
640px	.flow stacks; arrows rotate → to ↓
760px	.grid-2/3/4 gain their columns; below this everything is single-column

Type does not need breakpoints – every heading step is a **clamp()**, so it scales continuously. If you find yourself adding a font-size media query, use a **clamp()** instead.

SEC.07

7 • SPACING ON AN INK FIELD

Dark fields need slightly **more** air than bone ones, because the 2px bone rules on ink are visually heavier than 2px ink rules on bone. The system does not encode this as different tokens – instead:

- ▶ Prefer `-space-5` where you'd use `-space-4` for **padding inside** a panel on ink.
- ▶ Section padding stays the same. The change is local to components, not regions.
- ▶ `-ink-line` (`#5c554c`) dashed dividers are lower contrast than their bone-field counterparts by design; give rows one extra step of vertical padding so the dash still separates.

SEC.08

8 • PRINT SPACING

See `08-print.md` `RL-BRAND-001-PRINT` for the full print setup. The spacing translation:

SCREEN	PRINT
<code>-space-4</code> 16px	4mm
<code>-space-6</code> 34px	8mm
<code>-space-8</code> 64px	15mm
Page margin	15mm minimum, 18mm preferred
Rules	0.5pt for 1px dashed, 1.5pt for 2px solid – do not go below 1pt on the structural rule or it disappears at press

SEC.09

QUICK REFERENCE

CSS

```
/* the nine steps */
--space-1: 4px;  --space-4: 16px;  --space-7: 48px;
--space-2: 8px;  --space-5: 24px;  --space-8: 64px;
--space-3: 12px; --space-6: 34px;  --space-9: 72px;

/* containers */
--container: 1060px; --container-wide: 1160px; --container-prose: 900px;
--measure: 66ch;      --gutter: 4vw;

/* the three numbers to memorise */
16px  default padding and paragraph spacing
34px  under every section head, and every grid gap
64px  section padding
```

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